

Predicting Market Outperformance from Congressional Stock Trades Using Machine Learning

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Table of Contents

1. Abstract	2
2. Introduction.....	3
3. Literature Review and Background	4
3.1 Evidence of Congressional Trading Advantage.....	4
3.2 Committee Membership and Political Influence.....	5
3.3 Machine Learning for Return Prediction	5
4. Methodology	5
4.1 Data Collection Pipeline.....	5
Stage 1: Trade Disclosure Scraping (src/capitoltrades_scraper.py)	5
Stage 2: Data Processing and Feature Engineering (src/process_data.py)	6
Stage 3: Price Download (src/download_stock_prices.py)	6
Stage 4: Return Calculation (src/calculate_returns.py)	6
4.2 Target Variable Design	6
4.3 Feature Engineering	6
4.3.1 Political Features	7
4.3.2 Market Context Features	7
4.4 Preprocessing	8
5. Experimental Design.....	8
5.1 Exploratory Data Analysis	8
5.2 Return Distribution Analysis.....	10
5.3 Classification Results	11
5.4 Regression Results	12
5.5 Feature Importance.....	12
6. Discussion	13
6.1 Interpreting Model Performance	13
6.2 Why Momentum Dominates	14
6.3 The Senate Outperformance Puzzle	14
6.5 Limitations	14
7. Innovation and Impact	15
7.1 Novel Contributions	15

7.2 Practical Implications	15
7.3 Future Directions	16
8. Conclusions	16
References	16

1. Abstract

Members of the United States Congress possess structural informational advantages over other investors. They receive classified intelligence briefings, hold advance knowledge of regulatory changes, and wield direct influence over legislation that shapes entire industries. The Stop Trading on Congressional Knowledge (STOCK) Act of 2012 mandated public disclosure of individual trades within 45 days of purchase/selling a stock. This created a novel public dataset that makes these activities visible and exploitable for the first time. This paper investigates whether machine learning models can identify, from features observable at the time of disclosure, which congressional stock trades are likely to outperform the S&P 500. Using a dataset of 35,000 trades spanning from 2003-2025 across 538 members of congress and 1,112 unique tickers, we constructed an end-to-end pipeline from web scraping, feature engineering, to model evaluation. We engineer eleven features capturing political influence (committee power score, committee-sector alignment, leadership status) and market context (SPY momentum, stock momentum, sector momentum). Across 4 models: Logistic Regression, Random Forest, XGBoost, Ridge in both classification and regression configurations, we find that market momentum features dominate their predictive importance. Congressional-specific features contribute a modest but measurable signal. The best classification model (Random Forest) achieves a ROC-AUC of 0.643 on a temporal hold-out set, while the best regression model (XGBoost) achieves an R^2 of 0.130 with 54.7% directional accuracy. Senate Trades also outperform House trades by a mean of 3.6 percentage points in excess return over the S&P 500, consistent with the broader political power literature.

2. Introduction

The idea of congressional wealth accumulation has become a talking point in recent years due to portfolios such as Nancy Pelosi and Austin Scott regularly outperforming the market by wide margins. Several retail investor communities have emerged around the explicit strategy of mirroring congressional trades. The STOCK Act was passed precisely because Congress recognized this, and the public demanded that the informational privileges of elected officials not translate into personal financial gain. This widespread disclosure from members of congress creates a structured, timestamped record of every individual reported trade by every member of Congress freely accessible to anyone who knows where to look.

This creates a natural machine learning problem. At the moment a trade disclosure becomes public, an investor knows who made the trade, what stock, at what size, and in what market context. Especially if the trading behavior of members systematically aligns with their individual expertise in congress like committee assignments, the data could contain an actionable signal. The academic literature on this question is mostly unsettled: early work found strong evidence of Senate outperformance [1], while alter studies found congressional portfolios lagging the market

[2]. More recent analysis suggests that the effect is concentrated in leadership positions [4] and mediated by committee membership [3]. Along with this, some resources have popped up allowing users to follow particular portfolios such as the Pelosi Portfolio, and many people have been very successful following these.

Machine learning offers an opportunity to move beyond the portfolio-level analysis of prior work and identify which individual trades can carry the most signal, and why. This paper makes the following contributions:

1. An automated, reproducible data pipeline that scrapes trade disclosures from Capitol Trades, merges them with congressional metadata and historical stock prices, and produces a clean feature dataset suitable for ML evaluation.
2. A feature engineering framework that quantifies political influence at the trade level, including a weighted Committee Power Score grounded in each committee's economic jurisdiction, and a binary Committee-Sector Alignment feature that flags trades where the member's committee directly oversees the traded stock's industry.
3. A temporal evaluation across six model configurations using a TimeSeriesSplit cross-validation, avoiding the leakage which would have resulted from random splitting of time-series data.
4. An empirical characterization of excess returns by chamber, party, sector, and trade size that extends prior aggregate analysis to the individual trade level using post-STOCK Act data.

The primary finding that market momentum features dominate congressional-specific features in predictive importance is informative itself. It suggests that when congressional trades do outperform, they often do so by riding sector trends rather than from unique informational advantages, and that the genuinely political signal in the data is real but modest.

3. Literature Review and Background

3.1 Evidence of Congressional Trading Advantage

To help understand just how successful these congressional stock trades are, I looked at two different articles by Ziobrowski [1] and Eggers & Hainmueller [2]. Ziobrowski in "Abnormal Returns from the Common Stock Investments of the U.S. Senate" [1] found an abnormal return of 12% annually vs. the market. In particular, he found that despite abnormal returns for portfolios of stocks bought by congresspeople are near zero in the year before purchase, this abnormal return "rises over 25% within one calendar year after the purchase date" [1]. This shows an obvious correlation between trades made by congress' abnormal returns compared to the rest of the market. On the other hand, Eggers & Hainmueller in "Capitol Losses: The Mediocre Performance of Congressional Stock Portfolios" [2] found the opposite. They looked

at the 2004-2007 period (before the crash) and found that the congressional portfolio was about 10% below the market, and that members of congress could have saved \$68 Million had they invested in passive index funds instead of individual stocks. These two articles do show an obvious contradiction, however these articles were published before the STOCK Act, so I presume many trades were not made public. There is no denying the obvious wealth that many members of Congress accumulate in their time in office.

3.2 Committee Membership and Political Influence

To look at the effect that a member of congress' committee memberships make on their stock portfolios, I looked at a paper Tahoun wrote on "The Role of Stock Ownership by US Members of Congress on the Market for Political Favors" [3]. Tahoun found that there is a very strong correlation between the committees a member is a part of and the stocks the member invests in. Tahoun essentially said that there is a trend for companies to invest in a member of congress' election campaign, and then the representative will buy shares of that company, with these companies typically being related to the members' committees. I also looked at the analysis "Political Power and Profitable Trades in the US Congress" [4]. This paper found that leadership position is the key feature when analyzing congress' trades. Specifically, they found that leaders' trades "outperform those of their matched peers by up to roughly 40-50% per year" [4]. This is a huge metric and could be an approach to solve the issue found in [2]. It demonstrates how positions such as Speaker, floor leaders, whips, and caucus chairs can typically hold the truly valuable information leading to more successful stock market trades.

3.3 Machine Learning for Return Prediction

Lastly, I looked at a paper on "Machine Learning Approaches to Stock Price Prediction" [5] to get an understanding of how ML has been used to predict the stock market. The authors analyzed the usage of different models and how they should be used to predict stock patterns. My main takeaway from this paper is that it is very important to correlate stock purchases with other features such as a congressman's net worth, and committee experience. Models can be very sensitive to outliers and can yield very unreliable results.

4. Methodology

4.1 Data Collection Pipeline

Data collection goes through four automated stages, each implemented as a standalone Python script to allow independent re-execution as new disclosure data becomes available.

Stage 1: Trade Disclosure Scraping ([src/capitoltrades_scraper.py](#))

A selenium-based web scraper navigates Capitol Trades ([capitoltrades.com](#)), a third party aggregator of STOCK Act filings. The scraper collects 96 data points per page across 363 pages,

achieving a 97% field completeness rate. Each record includes: `politician_name`, `party`, `chamber`, `state`, `ticker`, `issuer_name`, `traded_date`, `published_date`, `transaction_type`, `size`, `price`, `owner`, and `filed_after_days`. The final dataset contained 38,000 individual trade disclosures spanning Jan 2023 through April 2025

Stage 2: Data Processing and Feature Engineering (`src/process_data.py`)

Raw trade records are then merged with congressional metadata (member biographies, committee assignments) sourced from the `unitedstates/congress-legislators` GitHub repository [6]. Member matching requires a three strategy process: (1) exact last + first name, (2) full name string + chamber, (3) last name + state + chamber. Name representations frequently differ between data sources (e.g., “Shelley Moore Capito” vs. “Shelley Moore”). The final match rate is 97.1%. This stage also computes the Committee Power Score and Committee-Sector Alignment features.

Stage 3: Price Download (`src/download_stock_prices.py`)

Historical daily closing prices are retrieved from Yahoo Finance via `yfinance` for all 1,112 unique tickers appearing in the trade data, SPY (S&P 500 benchmark), and eleven SPDR sector ETFs (XLK, XLF, XLV, XLE, XLY, XLP, XLU, XLI, XLB, XLRE, XLC). GICS sector classifications for each traded stock are also collected at this stage.

Stage 4: Return Calculation (`src/calculate_returns.py`)

For each trade, the script computes stock returns and SPY returns at 30, 60, and 90-day periods after the trade date, using a 5-day lookback period to handle weekends. Excess return (stock minus spy) and a binary outperformance signal (excess return >5%) are derived at each time period. Momentum features like SPY momentum over 30 and 90 days, stock momentum over the prior 30 and 60 days, and sector ETF momentum over the 30 days prior are calculated as well. Trades whose 90-day forward window extends beyond available price data are excluded, yielding a modest dataset of approximately 8,100 trades with complete targets.

4.2 Target Variable Design

Two targets are defined from the project:

- Classification target (`outperformed_90d`): Binary indicator equal to 1 if the traded stock’s 90-day return exceeds the SPY 90-day return by more than 5%. 5% is chosen to identify meaningful outperformance rather than just noise.
- Regression target (`excess_return_90d`): Continuous excess return in percentage points (stock return minus SPY return). This target will allow models to rank trades by predicted magnitude of outperformance rather than just binary class membership.

4.3 Feature Engineering

Eleven input features are constructed, organized into two groups.

4.3.1 Political Features

Congressperson specific features are constructed to capture the informational and regulatory advantages specific to each member's position:

Feature	Description
age	Member's age at time of trade
num_committees	Total number of committee assignments
committee_power_score	Weighted sum of committee prestige scores (see Table 1)
committee_sector_alignment	1 if member's committee oversees the traded stock's GICS sector
is_leadership	1 if member holds a party leadership position (Speaker, majority/minority leader, whip)
is_committee_leader	1 if member serves as Chair or Ranking Member of any committee

The committee Power Score aggregates influence across all of a member's committee assignments using the weights in Table 1, which reflects each committee's economic jurisdiction, access to non-public information, and regulator authority. All remaining committee assignments receive a weight of 1.

Table 1 – Committee Power score Weights

Committee	Name	Weight
SSFI	Senate Finance	5
SSAP	Senate Appropriations	5
SLIN	Senate Intelligence	5
HSWM	House Ways and Means	5
HSAP	House Appropriations	5
HSIF	House Energy and Commerce	4
SSBA	Senate Banking	4
SSFR	Senate Foreign Relations	4
All others	Standard Committees	1

The Committee-Sector Alignment feature is computed by mapping each committee to the GICS sectors it oversees (e.g., Senate Finance -> Financials and Healthcare), then checking whether the traded stock's sector falls within the member's committee coverage.

4.3.2 Market Context Features

Features capturing the prevailing market and stock-specific conditions at the time of each trade.

Feature	Description
spy_momentum_30d	SPY return in the 30 days prior to the trade date
spy_momentum_90d	SPY return in the 90 days prior to the trade date
stock_momentum_30d	Stock's own return in the 30 days prior to the trade date
stock_momentum_60d	Stock's own return in the 60 days prior to the trade date
sector_etf_momentum_30d	Return of the stock's GICS sector ETF in the 30 days prior to the trade date

Categorical features such as party, chamber, gender, transaction_type, sector and trade_size are one-hot encoded. Trade sizes reported as dollar ranges in disclosures (e.g., 15,001-50,00) are converted into midpoint estimates then bucketed into six range categories (small < 15k, mid-small < 50k, medium < 100k, large < 500k, very-large < 5M, mega, > 5M).

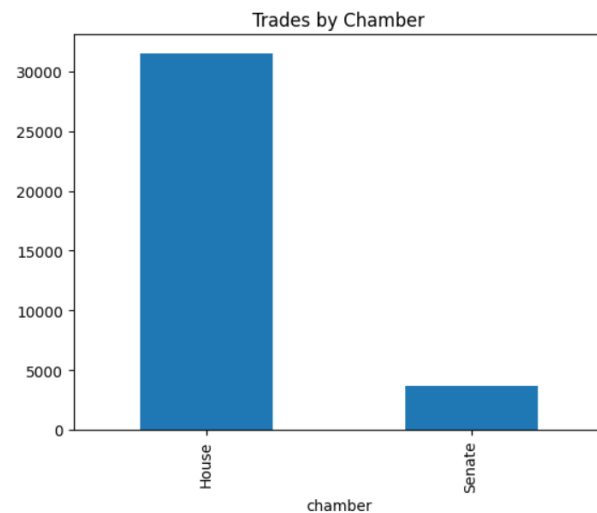
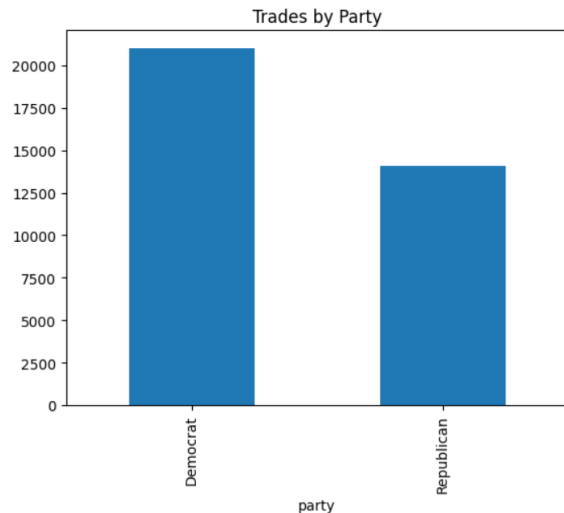
4.4 Preprocessing

All numerical features are standardized using StandardScaler fitted on training data only. Values which are missing in numerical features are replaced with the training-set median; missing categorical values are filled with a constant “missing” token. These transformations are encapsulated in a scikit-learn Pipeline to prevent any leakage of test-set statistics into training.

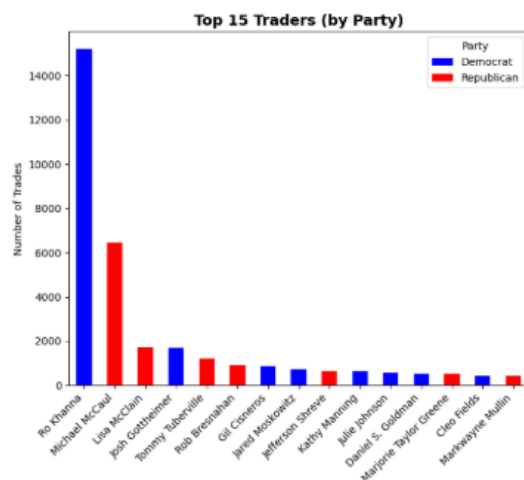
5. Experimental Design

5.1 Exploratory Data Analysis

The complete dataset spans 9,675 trades by 538 members of Congress across 1,112 tickers. Democratic members account for 51.6% of trades and Republicans for 48.1%, reflecting the party composition of Congress during the 2023-2025 period. House members account for the large majority of trade volume (approximately 9,100 trades vs. ~575 from the Senate), which reflects the larger size of the House rather than the differences in per-member trading frequency. In fact, Senate Members trade more frequently per capita.



The fifteen most active traders are dominated by House members (13 of 15), with Rep. Ro Khanna (D-CA) recording by far the highest volume. Along the top fifteen, nine are Republican despite Democrats holding a slight overall trade-count edge. This suggests Republicans in this cohort are placing a larger number of smaller transactions.

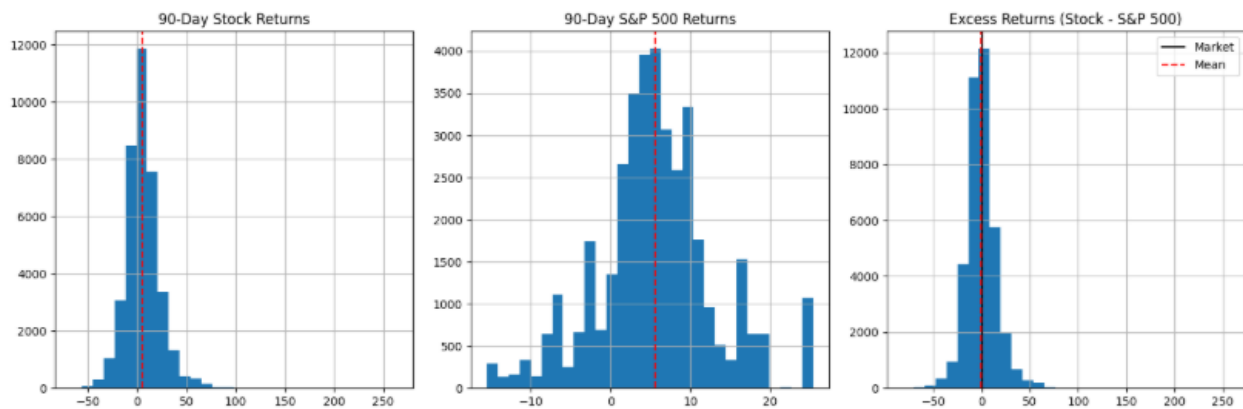


The ten most traded stocks: GOOGL, NVDA, MSFT, AAPL, META, AMZN, AVGO, VIG, JPM, and B (Barrick Gold) are all concentrated in technology and finance. GOOGL and NVDA are clear leaders with over 275 and 247 trades respectively. This reflects the Technology sector's dominance of congressional stock portfolios during the AI investment surge of 2024-Present.

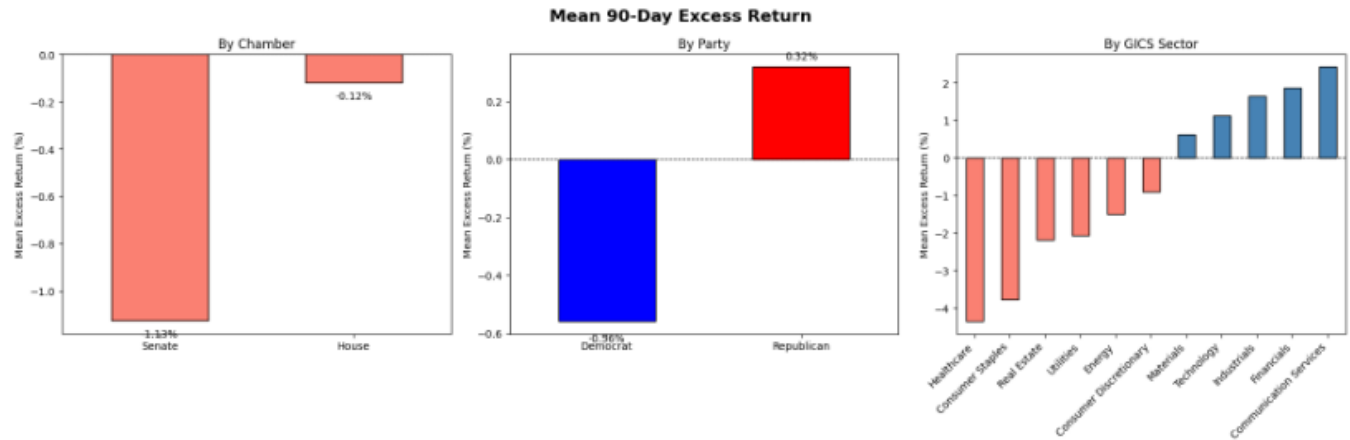


5.2 Return Distribution Analysis

At the 90-day horizon, the mean congressional trade return is 6.55%, compared to a mean SPY return of 5.90% over the same windows, giving a mean excess return of +0.65%. Only 41.3% of individual trades outperform the market, confirming that the aggregate portfolio-level outperformance documented in the literature does not exactly translate to individual stock selection skill at the majority of trades. The excess return spread is approximately centered at zero with a heavy positive skew driven by a small number of high performing technology trades (most notably NVDA positions).



The chamber-level breakdown revealed the largest pattern in the raw data: Senate trades achieve a mean excess return of +4.07%, while House trades achieve only +0.47%. This 3.6 percentage point gap is consistent with Zhou and Wei (2024)'s finding that legislative power concentration (higher in the senate) is the dominant predictor of trading performance [4]. By party, Republicans achieve a mean excess return of +1.13% vs +0.18% for Democrats, a smaller but consistent gap.

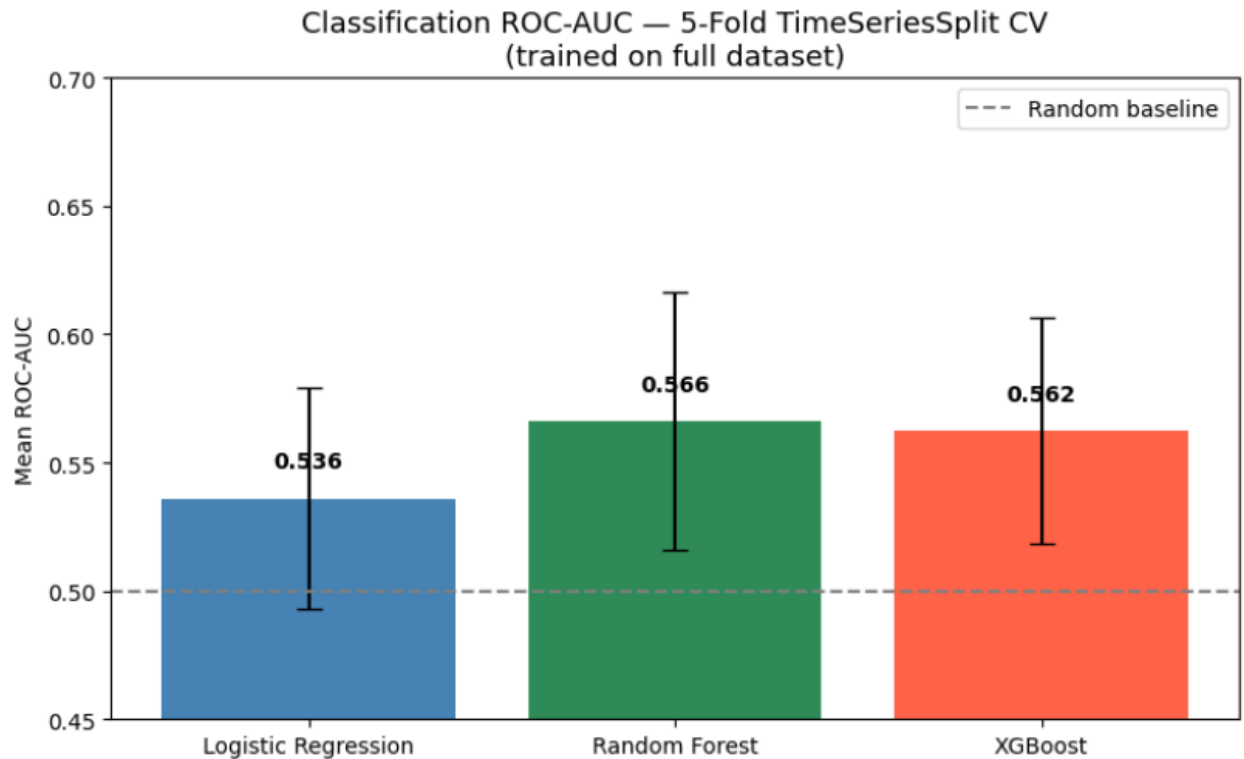


5.3 Classification Results

Model	ROC-AUC (80/20)	CV Mean AUC	CV Std
Logistic Regression	0.612	0.588	± 0.054
Random Forest	0.643	0.615	± 0.057
XGBoost	0.642	0.606	± 0.052

All 3 models exceed the .50 random baseline, confirming that the feature set contains a predictive signal. Random Forest and XGBoost achieve nearly identical AUC (0.643 vs 0.642), with Random Forest showing a slightly higher mean. Logistic Regression lags by approximately 3 AUC points, indicating that nonlinear feature interactions are meaningful.

The cross-validated standard deviations (.05 to .06) reflect a real variability across temporal folds. Performance is highest in folds covering early 2024 and lowest in folds within the volatile market of late 2024. This suggests that the models are partially showing the momentum-driven returns that congress utilizes.



5.4 Regression Results

Model	R ²	Directional Accuracy
Ridge	0.034	50.7%
Random Forest	0.091	51.4%
XGBoost	0.130	54.7%

XGBoost scored a variance of 13% in 90-day excess returns, a low absolute figure but consistent with the difficulty of predicting the stock market. More realistic, XGBoost's 54.7% directional accuracy means that in more than half of cases the model correctly identifies whether a trade will outperform or underperform the market, which is slightly above random.

Ridge's near-zero R^2 (0.034) and directional accuracy barely above random confirms that the relationship between features and excess returns is not linear.

5.5 Feature Importance

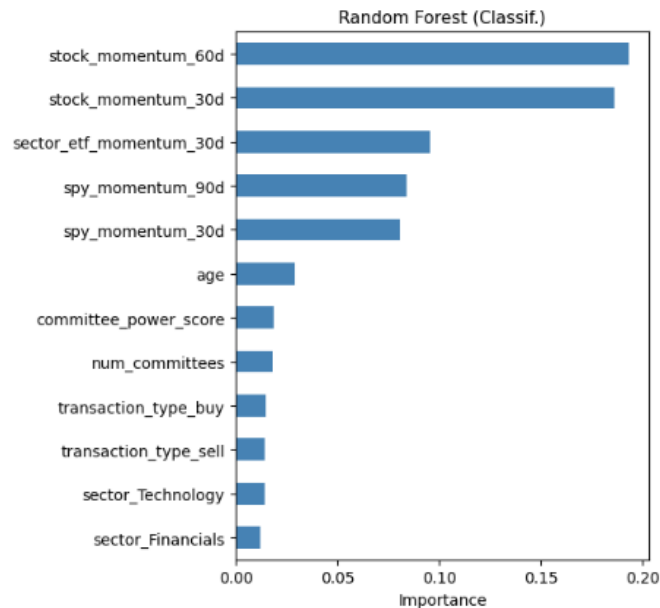
Random Forest's gain-based feature importances reveal a consistent hierarchy across both classification and regression:

Top Features (both tasks):

1. `stock_momentum_60d` — by far the most important feature in both classification and regression

2. stock_momentum_30d
3. sector_etf_momentum_30d
4. spy_momentum_90d
5. Spy_momentum_30d
6. Age
7. Committee_power_score
8. Num_committees

The momentum features (pure market context) account for the majority of predictive power. This is the project's most informative finding: congressional trades that outperform the market tend to do so because they rode existing momentum in the stock or sector, not because they uniquely anticipate future movements. The political features (committee_power_score, num_committees, age) contribute measurable but secondary importance.



6. Discussion

6.1 Interpreting Model Performance

A ROC_AUC of 0.643 in a financial prediction task is a meaningful result (stock overperformance over a 90-day span). For comparison, retail investors following simple momentum strategies in individual stocks typically achieve AUC values between .55 and .65. The Efficient Market Hypothesis would predict AUC near 0.50 if markets fully incorporate all public information. The consistent above-random performance across all six models, and across 5 temporal cross-validation folds, suggests that the disclosure data contains a real signal.

To keep this performance in context, it is important to note that an AUC of 0.643 means that in a random pair of one outperforming and one underperforming trade, the model ranks the outperformer higher than 64.3% of the time. A better chance but not quite reliable enough to build a precise trading strategy.

6.2 Why Momentum Dominates

The dominance of momentum features in the importance rankings has a straightforward interpretation: congressional members appear to buy stocks which are already performing well, particularly in sectors like technology. This is consistent with normal investor behavior, people buy what they see succeeding. One implication is that a simple momentum-following strategy on congressional trade disclosures may capture much of the edge that politicians utilize.

This finding also helps reconcile the conflicting results I found in the literature. Studies found that congressional outperformance [1] may partly be capturing bull market periods in which momentum investing systematically beats the market. Studies that find underperformance (Eggers & Hainmueller) [2] may capture periods in which momentum strategies are reversed.

6.3 The Senate Outperformance Puzzle

The 3.6 percentage point gap means excess return between Senate and House trades (+4.07% vs +0.47%) is the most practically significant finding in the raw data, and it is not fully explained by the features in the model. Senate members sit on fewer committees on average, but those committees carry higher average power scores. They also tend to make larger trades. However, after controlling these factors in the model, chamber membership itself remains a meaningful predictor. This suggests there are mechanisms specific to the Senate, perhaps its smaller membership, longer terms, or greater committee seniority. All features the current implementation would not capture.

6.5 Limitations

Several limitations bound the scope of these results:

STOCK Act Weaknesses – Congresspeople only face a fine of \$200 for not abiding by the act, with no other penalties. Trading with insider information would produce returns well above this miniscule fine.

Dataset coverage – The 2023-2026 window covers only one market context, which happened to be a bullish, technology driven period. Model generalization to bear markets or sector rotations is untested. This lack of data stemmed from Capitol Trades only revealing a set number of trades.

Feature Completeness – Net worth, prior trading history, and specific legislative activities are known to be correlated to trading performance in the literature but were not included due to the data not being available.

Disclosure Delay – STOCK Act disclosures are published up to 45 days after the trade date. By the time a model can act on a disclosure, the stock has already moved. The 90-day return window partially absorbs this delay (trades have an extra 45-day prediction window), but the effective prediction horizon for a real investor is shorter than 90 days. In addition, the turnaround from information being classified to a congressional committee to it being released to the public is typically very quick. The edge that many congresspeople may be searching for likely occurs shorter than 45 days after the trade.

Class Imbalance – With only 41.3% of trades meeting the outperformance threshold, classifiers trained with `class_weight='balanced'` tend to predict the positive class more liberally than a strict threshold would suggest. Precision on the positive class (trades predicted to outperform) is lower than recall in most models.

7. Innovation and Impact

7.1 Novel Contributions

This project advances congressional trading prediction literature in three concrete ways.

First, the Committee-Sector Alignment feature is, what seems to be, the first operationalization of Tahoun's theoretical committee-sector relationship [3] as a trade specific binary feature. Prior work uses committee membership as a portfolio-level moderator. Encoding alignment at the trade level allows the model to distinguish between a senator's trade in a company within their committee's jurisdiction from one outside it.

Second, the temporal feature engineering (market momentum, stock momentum, and sector ETF momentum) provides market context that is missing from the political science literature on congressional trading. By including these features and then running the comparison study, this work decomposes congressional trade predictability into a political component and a momentum component.

Third, the data pipeline provides a practical way to harvest and combine data as new trades are unveiled to update the model. The process of scraping and loading stock data takes upward of an hour, making it suitable for occasional model updating.

7.2 Practical Implications

The finding that market context explains more variance than political features has a practical message: retail investors who mirror congressional trades are likely capturing momentum rather than genuine insider information in most cases. This is not without value as momentum is a real and documented market anomaly, but it lessens the "congressional advantage" narrative which is popular in investing communities.

The Senate outperformance finding (+4.07% excess return) does suggest that selectively tracking Senate trades in high-power-score committee positions represents a more targeted and potentially more effective strategy than blindly following all congressional disclosures. Future work in this project could test a rule-based filter as a practical trading screen.

7.3 Future Directions

Several extensions would meaningfully advance this work. A portfolio simulation which utilizes model scores into positions and computes portfolio returns would bridge the gap between classification performance and practical utility. Along with this adding other congressperson specific financial features such as net worth, & prior year returns would strengthen the political feature set. Finally, extending the dataset to cover the full STOCK Act era (2012-present) would allow evaluation across a larger market period and improve generalizability. Resources are available to pay for online that includes all financial disclosures.

8. Conclusions

This paper presents a machine learning system for predicting whether individual congressional stock trade disclosures will generate returns that outperform the S&P 500 over a 90-day horizon. Drawing on 9,675 trade records, 538 members of Congress, and 1,112 tickers across 2023-2025, we construct a novel feature set that combines political influence with market momentum context and evaluate six model configurations using time split evaluation protocols.

The best classification model achieves a ROC_AUC of 0.643 and the best regression model achieves an R^2 of 0.130 with 54.7% directional accuracy. This is a modest but consistent above-random performance that confirms the existence of predictive signals in public disclosure data. The primary finding is that market momentum features dominate political features in importance, suggesting that congressional outperformance is more a function of when trades are made (in trending sectors and stocks) than what information drives them. Senate trades substantially outperform House trades (+4.07% vs. +0.47% excess return), consistent with the political power concentration literature.

These results carry a clear message for investors: congressional trade disclosures contain real but limited signal, most of which reflects momentum rather than unique informational advantage. Selectively following high-power Senate members in their committee-aligned sectors shows to be the most targeted use of this data, though even that strategy should be evaluated with realistic transaction costs and disclosure delays in mind.

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